

Haligric Research Integration Series

YAZIDISM

A COMPLETE DEEP DIVE

*The Peacock Angel, the Seven Mysteries, Lalish, and the Most Persecuted Religious Minority
in the World*

"Melek Taus wept for 7,000 years.

His tears extinguished the fires of hell.

*Hell no longer exists because the most beautiful of all sacred beings
was willing to weep long enough to end it."*

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A Note on Yazidi Sacred Knowledge and Community Sovereignty

The Yazidi community maintains specific restrictions on sharing their most sacred knowledge with non-Yazidis -- reflecting both ancient tradition and the specific trauma of centuries of persecution in which their sacred practices were used against them. This document presents what Yazidi scholars, cultural representatives, and researchers working with Yazidi communities have made publicly available. The Yazidi community's sovereignty over their sacred knowledge is honored and their ongoing struggle for recognition is acknowledged.

Introduction -- Who the Yazidi Are: The Most Persecuted Religious Minority

The Yazidis are a Kurdish-speaking religious community of approximately 700,000-1,000,000 people concentrated primarily in the Sinjar region of northern Iraq, with additional communities in Syria, Turkey, Armenia, Georgia, and a diaspora of approximately 200,000 primarily in Germany. They practice one of the world's oldest syncretic sacred traditions -- a synthesis of ancient Mesopotamian, Zoroastrian, Islamic, and pre-Islamic Kurdish elements that has been in continuous development for at least a thousand years and in some elements traces to the oldest sacred traditions of the Fertile Crescent.

The Yazidi have been the target of at least 74 documented genocides in their history -- the most recent in August 2014, when ISIS launched a systematic campaign of murder, enslavement, and forced displacement against the Yazidi community of the Sinjar region. The Yazidi community is still recovering. August 3, 2024 marked the 10th anniversary of the genocide, with commemoration ceremonies at the Yazidi Genocide Memorial in Solagh, inaugurated in November 2023. The UN formally recognized the ISIS campaign against the Yazidis as genocide in 2016.

Yazidi Identity -- Kurdish People, Distinct Religion

Yazidis are ethnically Kurdish but religiously distinct from the majority of Kurds, who are Muslim. Their religion is not a variant of Islam, Christianity, or any other Abrahamic faith -- it is a distinct sacred tradition that predates the current form of any of those traditions and that incorporates elements from multiple ancient streams. Yazidi identity is specifically defined by birth -- one cannot convert to Yazidism, and Yazidis who marry outside the community lose their Yazidi religious identity. This endogamous structure is one of the most contested features of the tradition from an outsider perspective, but it reflects the tradition's understanding of itself as a sacred hereditary community rather than a faith open to universal adoption. The oral transmission: Yazidi sacred knowledge is primarily transmitted orally -- the specific sacred songs (qewl), the specific sacred texts, and the most restricted ceremonial knowledge are held in memory and transmitted through the Qawwal (the hereditary sacred musician-priests who are the tradition's living archive).

The Fundamental Misunderstanding -- Why They Are Not Devil-Worshippers

The Yazidi have been labeled as devil-worshippers (in Arabic: Shaytan-perest) by their Muslim neighbors -- an accusation that has been used to justify persecution across centuries. The accusation is based on a fundamental misunderstanding: Melek Taus (the Peacock Angel, the Yazidis' primary intercessory being) has been identified with Iblis/Satan by Muslim critics because both refused to bow before Adam when commanded by God. But the Yazidi understanding of this refusal is entirely different from the Islamic understanding of

Iblis's rebellion -- in the Yazidi tradition, Melek Taus's refusal was an act of absolute monotheistic devotion (refusing to bow before anything other than the Creator), not an act of pride or rebellion. The misunderstanding is not accidental; it has served the interests of those seeking to justify persecution. The Yazidis do not worship Satan, recognize the concept of Satan in any form consonant with the Abrahamic framework, or engage in any practice that resembles what their accusers claim.

The syncretic character: Yazidism is genuinely syncretic -- it incorporates elements from Zoroastrianism (the sacred fire, the cosmic dualism framework), from Sufism and Islam (Sheikh Adi ibn Musafir, one of the tradition's founding figures, was a Sufi teacher), from older Mesopotamian and Kurdish sacred traditions, and from its own distinctive theological developments. This synthesis character makes it deeply resonant with the Haligricity tradition. The Yazidi tradition demonstrates that syncretic sacred traditions are among the most vulnerable to persecution by communities that cannot tolerate complexity.

Yazidi Cosmology -- The Seven Sacred Beings

Yazidi cosmology understands the universe as created by Khwede (the supreme Creator) and governed through seven sacred angels (the Heft Sirr -- the Seven Mysteries or Seven Holy Beings) who were created by Khwede to govern the different dimensions of the created world. This seven-fold cosmological structure -- a sacred heptad -- is one of the most ancient numerical frameworks in the Fertile Crescent, paralleling the seven planets of ancient Mesopotamian astronomy, the seven Amesha Spentas of Zoroastrianism, and numerous other seven-fold sacred structures across the region.

Khwede -- The Supreme Creator, Beyond All Attributes

Khwede (from the Kurdish khuda -- God, lord) is the supreme Creator in Yazidi theology -- a being so transcendent that the Yazidi tradition tends toward apophatic theology (defining the divine by what it is not rather than by positive attributes). Khwede is beyond all human description and beyond all the names and attributes that religious traditions typically assign to the divine. Khwede created the world and then delegated its governance to the seven sacred angels -- a pattern that removes the transcendent Creator from direct involvement in the messy specifics of the created world and places them in the hands of beings who can be in relationship with the human community.

Melek Taus -- The Peacock Angel

Melek Taus (from Arabic malik -- king/angel, and the Persian tawus -- peacock: "the Peacock King/Angel") is the supreme intercessory being in the Yazidi tradition -- the most beautiful of the seven sacred angels created by Khwede, whose specific role is the governance of the earth and the mediation between the Creator and the human community. Melek Taus is the chief of the seven sacred angels -- the most beautiful, the most powerful, and the most directly involved with the human world of the seven. The peacock -- with its extraordinary beauty, its hundreds of eyes, and its specific sacred character -- is his specific form and symbol.

The sacred bronze peacock images (sanjak) -- seven of them, one for each of the seven holy communities of the tradition -- are the most sacred material objects in Yazidism. They travel on a regular circuit between Yazidi communities throughout the year, carried by the Qawwal on their specific ritual routes. The presence of the sanjak in a community is one of the most important sacred events of the year. The sanjak were a specific target of ISIS in 2014: the desecration and destruction of sacred objects was part of the systematic effort to erase the tradition.

The Story of Melek Taus -- Pride, Fall, Weeping, and Redemption

When Khwede created the universe and then created Adam from the elements of the earth, He commanded all the angels to bow before Adam. All bowed except Melek Taus. In the Islamic tradition, this refusal by Iblis is the defining act of Satanic pride. In the Yazidi tradition, Melek Taus's refusal is the defining act of absolute devotion to the Creator: he refused to bow before anything created by the Creator because he would bow before the Creator alone. Khwede acknowledged the validity of this devotion and made Melek Taus the most honored of the seven sacred angels, entrusting him with the governance of the earth. THE TEARS AND THE FIRES OF HELL: Melek Taus was separated from the Creator for a specific period -- in some versions, placed in or near the fires of hell as a form of testing. For 7,000 years, Melek Taus wept -- and his tears were so abundant that they extinguished the fires of hell. The seven sacred vessels (the seven sanjak) were filled with his tears. Hell no longer exists in the Yazidi cosmology because Melek Taus's tears extinguished it.

HALIGRIC LENS: Melek Taus wept for 7,000 years and extinguished hell with his tears. This is not a minor theological point -- it is the most direct available statement in any tradition that the divine does not maintain punishment, that grief itself is sacred, and that the beauty of the divine (the peacock's beauty) and the grief of the divine (the 7,000 years of tears) are the same sacred force. The Haligrig tradition holds that the divine is not an external enforcer but the interior sacred reality of every being -- and Melek Taus's tears express this understanding more beautifully than any doctrine could.

The Seven Holy Beings (Heft Sirr) -- The Sacred Heptad

The seven sacred angels of Yazidi cosmology: Melek Taus (The Peacock Angel) -- Chief of the seven, governor of the earth, the primary intercessory being between Khwede and humanity. Sheikh Adi ibn Musafir -- A historical Sufi teacher (c. 1073-1162) who became the founding sacred figure of Yazidism as it is practiced today -- understood in Yazidi theology as a divine manifestation. His tomb at Lalish is the most sacred site in Yazidism. Sheikh Hasan -- The second most important sheikh-figure in the Yazidi sacred hierarchy. Yezid ibn Muawiya -- The Umayyad Caliph (historical figure, 680-683 CE) understood by Yazidis as a divine manifestation. This association is one of the most politically controversial elements of Yazidism, as Yazid is the caliph who killed the Prophet Muhammad's grandson Husayn at the Battle of Karbala (680 CE) -- making him the most hated figure in Shia Islam; Yazidi veneration of Yezid has contributed significantly to Muslim hostility toward the tradition. Sheikh Shams -- Associated with the sun and with illumination. Sheikh Fahr ad-Din -- The sacred being associated with the moon. Sheikh Nasir ad-Din -- The sacred being associated with specific sacred functions.

Sheikh Adi ibn Musafir -- The Founding Sacred Figure

Sheikh Adi ibn Musafir (c. 1073-1162 CE) was a historical figure -- a Sufi mystic from Lebanon who settled in the Lalish valley in northern Iraq and established a religious community there. In the Yazidi tradition, he is understood not merely as a founding religious teacher but as a divine manifestation -- one of the seven sacred beings who took human form to establish the tradition's institutional structures. His tomb at Lalish is the most sacred site in Yazidism, the primary destination of the annual pilgrimage, and the sacred center around which the tradition organizes its year. Sheikh Adi's role in Yazidism is analogous to the role of the Prophet in Islam or Jesus in Christianity -- the founding human-divine figure through whom the tradition's most important teachings and structures were established.

The Yazidi Sacred Books -- Kiteba Cilwe and Mishefa Re

Yazidism has two primary sacred texts: Kiteba Cilwe (the Book of Illumination) -- presenting the divine from the perspective of Melek Taus, describing his nature, his relationship with

the Creator, and his role in governing the earth; and Mishefa Re (the Black Book) -- a more cosmological text describing the creation, the origin of humanity, and the specific sacred practices and prohibitions that define Yazidi life. However, these texts represent the publicly accessible layer of a much larger body of sacred knowledge -- the oral tradition transmitted by the Qawwal (the sacred musicians) preserves the most complete and most restricted sacred knowledge. The decision about what may and may not be written is itself a sacred decision, and the most sacred content remains intentionally unwritten.

The Yazidi Sacred Calendar -- Festivals and Sacred Time

The Yazidi sacred year is organized around specific festivals that mark the major transition points in the relationship between the human community and the sacred world. Key festivals: The Feast of Seven Days (Cemaya Pir Hesen or Cemaya Lalish) -- the primary annual pilgrimage and communal gathering at Lalish in late September or early October; the most important event in the Yazidi sacred year. The Wednesday Ceremony -- a sacred weekly practice held on Wednesday (the Yazidi sacred day), involving specific candle lighting, specific prayers, and the renewal of the relationship with Melek Taus. Nowruz (the Persian/Kurdish New Year in March) -- celebrated with specific Yazidi ceremonies including the anointing of the serpent image at Lalish's entrance as part of the annual sacred renewal. Arbaje -- the Yazidi month of fasting (three days in December). Each festival represents a specific moment in the reciprocal sacred relationship between the Yazidi community and the seven holy beings.

The Feast of Seven Days (Cemaya Pir Hesen) -- Step-by-Step

Timing: Late September or early October -- the most important event in the Yazidi sacred year, drawing pilgrims from throughout Iraq, Syria, and the global diaspora.

Step 1 -- The Removal of Shoes: Pilgrims remove their shoes at Lalish's entrance -- the entire valley being sacred ground on which ordinary footwear is inappropriate.

Step 2 -- The Greeting of the Sacred Sites: Pilgrims visit each of the specific sacred sites within Lalish in a specific order -- the tomb of Sheikh Adi, the specific sacred rooms within the complex, the specific sacred springs and trees -- greeting each with specific prayers and specific physical acknowledgments (kissing the threshold, touching the sacred walls with specific intentions).

Step 3 -- The Sacred Spring: Pilgrims visit the Zam Zam spring and receive the sacred water -- used for drinking, for ceremonial purposes, and carried home in specific vessels as a sacred substance.

Step 4 -- The Knotting Ceremony: Specific colored cloths are tied around specific trees and sacred structures at Lalish -- each knot encoding a specific prayer or intention. The knotted cloths accumulate over generations, their fading colors a record of the community's sacred communications over time.

Step 5 -- The Collective Ceremonies: The Qawwal perform the sacred songs -- the tradition's living oral archive transmitted through music. The community assembles for specific collective ceremonies.

Step 6 -- The Feast: The assembly closes with communal feasting -- the sacred community's material solidarity expressed through shared food.

The Wednesday Ceremony -- The Sacred Weekly Practice

Wednesday is the Yazidi sacred day -- the specific day of the week on which specific household and community ceremonies are performed. The Wednesday ceremony involves: the lighting of sacred candles and olive oil lamps -- light as the most fundamental expression of sacred presence in the Yazidi tradition; specific prayers addressed to Melek Taus and the

seven holy beings; the avoidance of specific activities on Wednesday (agricultural work is specifically restricted); and the renewal of the household's relationship with the sacred community. The sacred fire maintained by each Yazidi household mirrors the sacred flame at Lalish -- a continuous burning that marks the household as a Yazidi sacred space.

Lalish -- The Sacred Valley and Pilgrimage, Step-by-Step

Lalish is the most sacred site in Yazidism -- a valley in the Shekhan district of the Kurdistan Region of Iraq, approximately 60 kilometers northeast of Mosul, where the tomb of Sheikh Adi ibn Musafir is located. For Yazidis, Lalish is the equivalent of Mecca, Jerusalem, and Varanasi simultaneously -- the specific sacred axis of the world, the place where the divine world is most directly accessible, and the destination of the tradition's primary pilgrimage. The valley of Lalish is understood as sacred in its entirety -- not merely the tomb complex but the entire landscape, including specific trees, specific stones, specific springs, and specific geographic features that carry specific sacred associations. At the entrance to the main temple complex, a serpent is carved in stone -- a sacred protective being, not associated with evil.

The Sacred Spring at Lalish -- The Yazidi Zamzam

At Lalish, a specific sacred spring -- called the Zam Zam (sharing its name with the sacred spring at Mecca, though the Yazidi spring is understood as distinct and specifically Yazidi sacred) -- provides the sacred water used in the most important Yazidi ceremonies, including the baptism. The sacred spring at Lalish is understood as the most powerful water in the world -- the specific water through which Melek Taus's blessing is most directly transmissible to the human community. Sacred water from the Lalish spring is carried home by pilgrims in specific vessels and used throughout the year as a sacred substance.

The Baptism Ceremony -- Step-by-Step

All Yazidis are baptized -- the ceremony that formally confirms the individual's membership in the Yazidi sacred community. The ceremony uses water specifically from the sacred spring at Lalish (or water that has been blessed and ritually connected to the Lalish spring), confirming that the sacred geography of Lalish is present in every baptism ceremony regardless of where it is performed. The baptism ceremony: specific preparation and purification; the specific prayers and invocations by the presiding religious specialist (typically a Sheikh or Pir); the ritual washing with sacred water; the specific words of blessing addressed to Melek Taus and the seven holy beings; the formal acknowledgment of the individual as a member of the Yazidi community with the rights and responsibilities that this membership entails.

The Sacred Fire and Fire Ceremony -- Step-by-Step

The sacred fire is one of the most ancient sacred elements of the Yazidi tradition -- reflecting the Zoroastrian influence in Yazidism's synthesis. The sacred flame at Lalish burns continuously -- maintained by specific sacred specialists, never allowed to go out, serving as the most visible expression of the tradition's continuity. The sacred flame is understood as Melek Taus's presence made visible in the material world. The fire ceremony: the lighting of the sacred fire on the appropriate ceremonial day (typically Wednesday evening); the gathering of the community around the fire; specific prayers and songs addressed to the sacred fire and through it to Melek Taus; the specific distribution of the fire's light (the lighting of household candles and lamps from the sacred fire). Each Yazidi household maintains a sacred lamp -- an olive oil lamp that is lit on sacred days and that connects the household's specific sacred space to the larger sacred fire at Lalish.

The Qawwal -- Sacred Musicians and the Transmission of Knowledge

The Qawwal are the hereditary sacred musicians of the Yazidi tradition -- the professional ritual singers and instrumentalists who are simultaneously the tradition's most important sacred specialists and its primary repository of sacred knowledge. The Qawwal transmit the sacred oral tradition through music -- the sacred songs (qewl) that contain the theology, the history, the ceremonial knowledge, and the sacred wisdom of the tradition in compressed, memorized, performative form. The Qawwal perform the qewl at the major festivals, at the Lalish pilgrimage, at the ceremonies that mark major life transitions (birth, marriage, death), and in the regular transmission sessions that maintain the oral tradition. They are under the specific protection of Melek Taus and hold a specific social position in the Yazidi caste system that acknowledges their function as the tradition's living archive.

The Qawwal Ceremony: The Qawwal assemble in the specific ceremonial order appropriate to the occasion. They tune their instruments (the tambur -- a long-necked lute -- and specific drums) with specific prayers. The leader of the Qawwal group opens the session with specific invocations of Melek Taus and the seven holy beings. The qewl are performed in their specific sequence, each one complete before the next begins. The audience participates through specific responses, through specific physical postures of respect, and through the collective emotional engagement that the tradition understands as a form of sacred attention.

The Yazidi Caste System -- Sheikhs, Pirs, and Murids

Yazidi society is organized into three hereditary castes: the Sheikhs (the religious leadership class, responsible for the performance of the most important ceremonies and the transmission of the most sacred knowledge), the Pirs (a second level of religious specialists, each Pir lineage associated with a specific community), and the Murids (the lay community -- the majority of Yazidis). The caste system is hereditary -- one is born into one's caste and the caste determines one's ceremonial role and one's specific sacred obligations. The Qawwal are a specific sub-group of the Sheikh caste, distinguished by their hereditary role as sacred musicians and oral transmitters. The caste system has been both a survival mechanism (maintaining the specific roles through centuries of persecution) and a source of internal community tension.

The 74 Genocides -- A History of Persecution

The Yazidi community counts 74 firman -- genocide decrees or systematic campaigns of persecution -- across their documented history. The number reflects not only the frequency of persecution but the specific form it took: the combination of the devil-worshipper accusation and the Yazidis' traditional pacifism and geographic concentration made them repeatedly vulnerable to violence from surrounding communities. The Ottoman period, the Safavid period, the British colonial period in Iraq, the Ba'athist period under Saddam Hussein (who conducted Arabization campaigns against the Yazidis in the 1960s-1970s, destroying 200 Yazidi villages in Sinjar) -- each political era produced its own form of persecution.

The ISIS Genocide (2014) -- The Sinjar Massacre and Its Aftermath

On August 3, 2014, ISIS forces overran the Sinjar region of northern Iraq -- the primary homeland of the Yazidi community. In the following days: an estimated 3,000-5,000 Yazidi men and elderly women were executed (mass graves have since been found); Yazidi women and girls were systematically taken as slaves, sold in markets, and subjected to sexual

violence on a mass scale; tens of thousands of Yazidis fled to the Sinjar Mountains -- where they were surrounded without water or food for days before Kurdish and American airdrops reached them; approximately 6,800 women and children were abducted by ISIS. The United Nations formally designated this as genocide in 2016. Nadia Murad -- a Yazidi woman from the village of Kocho who was captured by ISIS, enslaved, escaped, and became an internationally recognized human rights activist -- received the Nobel Peace Prize in 2018. Her testimony brought the Yazidi genocide to global attention.

Ten-year anniversary (August 3, 2024): Commemoration ceremonies were held at the Yazidi Genocide Memorial in Solagh, Sinjar, inaugurated November 2023. The Yazidi Supreme Spiritual Council's ruling acknowledging female survivors as full community members -- refusing to allow the stigma that their captivity-imposed conditions had created -- was among the most significant institutional responses of any religious tradition to systematic sexual violence against its members. As of 2025, approximately 2,500 Yazidis remain unaccounted for; approximately 2,700 women and girls remain missing or in captivity -- many years after ISIS's military defeat. Sinjar remains approximately 80% destroyed in terms of public infrastructure, with ongoing disputes between the Kurdish Regional Government and the Iraqi federal government over administration complicating reconstruction. UNITAD (the UN investigative team for accountability for ISIS crimes) was abruptly closed September 17, 2024, raising concerns about ongoing accountability efforts.

International accountability: Germany has handed down 9 convictions for crimes against Yazidis, including 3 specifically for genocide -- the first genocide convictions in German legal history. The Netherlands delivered its first conviction for crimes against Yazidis on December 11, 2024. Sweden and France have initiated legal proceedings. The Iraqi Yazidi Survivors Law (2021) established a reparations framework, though implementation has faced significant challenges. In April 2025 the Real Estate Registration Department in Sinjar began distributing land ownership letters to Yazidi residents, acknowledging Yazidi land rights recognized by the Iraqi government in 2022.

Contemporary Yazidi -- Diaspora, Accountability, and Survival

Germany is home to an estimated 200,000 Yazidis -- the largest Yazidi community outside Iraq. Additional significant diaspora communities exist in the United States, Canada, the UK, Sweden, and Australia. The global diaspora has been essential for the tradition's survival: Yazidi religious specialists who fled Iraq have established ceremonial practice in diaspora communities, and the oral transmission continues in new geographical contexts. Approximately 150,000 Yazidis have returned to Sinjar since 2015, but approximately 200,000 remain displaced in camps in the Kurdistan Region of Iraq as of 2024-2025. Over 600 returned from Duhok governorate to Sinjar in May 2025. The Lalish pilgrimage continues to draw the community from throughout Iraq and the global diaspora annually. The sacred flame at Lalish still burns. The Qawwal still transmit the sacred songs through oral memory. The sanjak images of Melek Taus still travel between Yazidi communities on their sacred circuit.

The Haligrity Lens -- The Synthesis Tradition That Survived

Yazidism offers Haligrity the most personally costly available example of what a synthesis sacred tradition requires to survive -- and the most extraordinary available example of what 74 genocides cannot destroy when the community holds its sacred identity with sufficient depth and sufficient love. Melek Taus wept for 7,000 years and extinguished hell with his tears. This is not a minor theological point -- it is the most direct available statement in any tradition that the divine does not maintain punishment, that grief itself is sacred, and that the beauty of the divine and the grief of the divine are the same sacred force.

They called the Yazidis devil-worshippers and used the misunderstanding to justify 74 genocides. The most recent was in 2014. ISIS tried to erase a people who had been worshipping the Peacock Angel for a thousand years -- a being whose tears extinguished the fires of hell, who refused to bow before anything less than the Creator, who is understood as the most beautiful of all sacred beings. The tradition survived 73 genocides before this one. It survived this one too. Nadia Murad received the Nobel Prize. The Qawwal still sing the sacred songs. The flame at Lalish still burns. The peacock angel still watches. Grand Rising.